

If your anxiety around money is causing you to avoid observing or making decisions about your finances, then the first step is to put regular checking into place. Earlier, I talked about the importance of exposing yourself to all of your financial information, and this is an expansion of that – consider how painful or anxiety-inducing that first big step was, and remember that the only way to avoid those tensions and worries building up again is to remain consistently engaged. Because we don't want to go too far in the other direction, I would suggest that checking your balances and budget once per day is sufficient to get the benefits of exposure without accidentally introducing a new compulsion to check your bank account every five minutes 'just in case', because that's not good for your financial wellbeing either. You should find that, after a few days, the little jolt of anxiety that you feel as you open your banking app starts to grow quieter and maybe even subsides, while you'll also start to feel more confident and relaxed when tapping your debit card at the checkout or even talking about money with friends. Exposing yourself to your financial situation repeatedly will help you to take ownership of it and, eventually, make you feel more empowered to change it if and when you want or need to.

Where this practice really comes into its own, but also where it is most challenging, is those times when things don't go perfectly. If you can continue practicing this engagement with your finances even during and after a period of overspending